

cover story SOCIETY

■ By Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai

Sex was a small price that wannabe Kannada actor Maria Susairaj was willing to pay for success in the country's glamour capital. She found the means to that end in Neeraj Grover, a media professional working with Synergy Adlabs, who would help her further her acting career in Bollywood. At the same time, she continued a long-distance relationship with steady boyfriend Lieutenant Emile Jerome, who loved her "desperately and wanted to get engaged", says Additional Commissioner of Mumbai Police (Crime) Deven Bharti. But while Susairaj was busy furthering her relationship with Grover, engagement with Jerome was not top priority. On May 6, when Susairaj realised Grover wasn't giving her a role, she turned to boyfriend Jerome, who flew down from Kochi to Mumbai on the morning of May 7 and killed Grover.

Call it a diabolical or primordial act of a jealous lover, but the darker side of India's sexual revolution is now coming to the fore, where passion is rarely accompanied by reason. Along with eating and drinking habits, sexual behaviour too has become globalised, where pursuit of heady pleasures isn't taboo and trading sexual favours for professional growth is no longer considered unethical. Gone are the days of straitjacketed relationships, which were defined by propriety and social acceptance. Today, what's sauce for the goose is sauce for the gander. As women gallop towards professional success, they are leaving convention and their *Laxman Rekhas* far behind.

CRIMES OF

Fast-track careers, insatiable ambition and sexual adventurism are stoking crimes of passion and rattling